Had it not been for the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan in December 1979, Zia might well have been forced to surrender the powers he had illegally grabbed from Bhutto. Most of Pakistan's moderate leaders, many of whom had despised Bhutto long before he was hanged, now feared and hated Zia's austere fanaticism much more than Bhutto's vulgarity or drunken orgies. But the swift conquest of Kabul by heavy Soviet tanks and helicopter gunships proved to be Zia's salvation. President Carter's offer of $400 million in military aid was so contemptuously dismissed by the general as "peanuts" that he suddenly became a hero to Pakistan's army and mullahs. Then President Reagan, who had defeated Carter in the 1980 presidential election, quickly raised the promised U.S. aid to our new "front line ally" in the Cold War to $10 billion, not only in tanks and planes, but also in new Stinger missiles capable of seeking out and destroying Soviet helicopters and tanks.